

◀ *Dec. 30, 2019*

The Swachhta Hero ▶ Parameswaran Iyer, then secretary, Department of Drinking Water & Sanitation, was featured on the INDIA TODAY cover after helming a toilet-building blitz: 106 million in 48 months under the Swachh Bharat Mission

for a new, welfare-driven model of governance.

The next few years would see a PM Yojana for every aspect of Indian life—Ujjwala for a free gas connection, Har Ghar Nal Se Jal for piped water supply, Saubhagya for universal electrification. Schemes that already existed were accorded scale, from a Gram Sadak Yojana to rural and urban housing schemes. There was something for everybody: a Mahila Samman Nidhi for women, a Kisan Samman Nidhi for farmers, a Mudra Yojana for small businesses, Vishwakarma for artisans, SVANidhi for the street vendor, Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao for the girl child.

Modi also gave the masses something they never had: a semblance of social security. Ayushman Bharat provided them health insurance, Suraksha Bima and Jeevan Jyoti accident and life insurance, and Atal Pension a modicum of income security.

But more than anything else, the one thing that made a real difference was delivery. Pronouncing the death of the middleman, India moved towards direct benefit transfer, aided by the JAM—Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, mobile—trinity. Digital India was changing the face of governance alongside, as services and record-keeping moved online.

But the more these schemes signalled change, the more some things remained the same. Poor implementation, underutilised funds, hype trumping reality, all these collectively became the graveyard of many a good intention. State schemes also found themselves competing against central ones, especially when they could be deployed as part of an electoral narrative.

The ordinary Indian, meanwhile, counted his blessings. Life changed, if not for the best, then certainly towards the better. ■

MODI'S FLAGSHIP SCHEMES

Coverage and outcomes of the biggest welfare programmes

PM JAN DHAN YOJANA
Launched
Aug. 28, 2014
Financial inclusion beneficiaries
572 million
Balance in their bank accounts
₹2.79 lakh cr.

PM AWAS YOJANA
Launched
Jun. 25, 2015
Rural houses built
28.2 million
Urban houses built
9.6 million

PM UJJWALA YOJANA
Launched
May 1, 2016
Total LPG connections released to poor women: **103 million**

PM SAHAJ BIJLI HAR GHAR YOJANA
Launched
Sept. 25, 2017
Houses electrified
28 million

AYUSHMAN BHARAT–PM JAN AROGYA YOJANA
Launched
Sept. 23, 2018
Health insurance cards issued
427 million
Authorised hospital admissions
99.6 million

JAL JEEVAN MISSION-HAR GHAR JAL
Launched
Aug. 15, 2019
Households provided with tap water connection
125 million

PM GARIB KALYAN ANNA YOJANA
Launched
Apr. 1, 2020
Beneficiaries receiving 5 kg free grains every month: **810 million**



◀ **Modicare: Will it Work?**
Feb. 19, 2018

"On February 1, about 41 minutes into his Budget 2018 speech, Union finance minister Arun Jaitley delivered the piece de resistance: "Madam Speaker, my government has now decided to take health protection to a more aspirational level." He outlined the National Health Protection Scheme, offering hospitalisation coverage of Rs 5 lakh a year to 100 million poor and vulnerable families. "This will be the world's largest government-funded healthcare programme," he promised."